

Module 4: Common Schools, Expansion, and Exclusion

EDUC 219 - Howard University

Nathan Alexander, PhD

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1 Module overview

This module examines the nineteenth-century expansion of common schools and the unequal educational systems that developed alongside them. We will study the common-school movement, immigration, urbanization, normal schools, teacher preparation, and the growing role of states and local communities in public education.

The module also emphasizes exclusion. As public schooling expanded, access was not distributed equally. Race, class, gender, disability, language, religion, immigration status, geography, and political power shaped who could enter schools, what kinds of schools they attended, what they were taught, and the resources available to them.

2 Guiding questions

- What was the common-school movement, and what problems was it intended to address?
- How did ideas about citizenship, democracy, morality, work, and social order shape public schooling?
- How did immigration, urbanization, industrialization, and population growth affect schools?
- What roles did normal schools and teacher preparation play in the expansion of education?
- Who benefited from expanding public education, and who continued to experience exclusion or unequal access?

- How did race, class, language, religion, gender, disability, and geography influence educational opportunity?
- How do nineteenth-century struggles over public education help us understand later segregation, unequal school funding, and disputes over access?

3 Key concepts

- Common-school movement
- Public education and state formation
- Citizenship and civic education
- Immigration and urbanization
- Industrialization and social order
- Normal schools and teacher preparation
- Compulsory schooling
- Educational access and exclusion
- Unequal resources and opportunity
- Historical significance and primary-source analysis

4 Readings and activities

- Givens (2021), Chapter 4
- Additional readings and media on Canvas
- Archival research presentations and findings
- Historical-timeline and database contributions
- Quiz 2
- Trial-group archival-evidence discussion and research

Trial connection

As you examine the development of public education, identify historical evidence that may help explain later systems of racial segregation, unequal access, school governance, citizenship, and legal conflict. Consider whether an event or artifact is connected to *Plessy v. Ferguson*, *Brown v. Board of Education*, both cases, or broader historical context.